

**STOP PITCHING.**

**START DIAGNOSING.**

**The Story Behind the NEED Cycle**

*A Practical Framework for Better Conversations, Better Coaching, Better Leadership, and Better Decisions*



**Kevin Young**

Learning & Development • Facilitation • Performance Coaching

*"Understanding the person before offering the solution."*

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## **The Story Behind the NEED Cycle**

**A Practical Framework for Better Conversations, Better Coaching, Better Leadership, and Better Decisions**

Written by

**Kevin Young**

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**Dedicated to every teacher, coach, leader, parent, salesperson, and mentor  
who understands that the greatest solutions begin with the greatest  
questions.**

# Foreword

Every once in a while, a simple idea stays with us for years.

For me, it came from an unexpected place, the 2005 animated movie *Robots*. Throughout the film, the character Bigweld lives by a philosophy that has stayed with me ever since:

**"See a need. Fill a need."**

At first, I admired it because it reflected the kind of person I wanted to be, someone who looked for opportunities to help others rather than waiting to be asked.

Over the years, however, my work in sales, leadership, coaching, training, and education taught me something equally important.

Before we can fill a need, we have to understand it.

Too often, we rush to provide answers before we've taken the time to truly understand the person in front of us. We hear what someone says they want, but we never explore why they want it, what challenges they're facing, or whether there's an even better solution waiting to be discovered.

That realization became the foundation of the NEED Cycle.

This guide isn't about selling more. It's about understanding better. Whether you're leading a team, coaching an employee, teaching a student, serving a customer, or simply having an important conversation, my hope is that the NEED Cycle encourages you to slow down, stay curious, and seek understanding before offering solutions.

After all, the best answers usually begin with the best questions.

**Kevin Young**

# Chapter 1

## Why I Created the NEED Cycle

For much of my career, I never set out to create a framework or write a guide. I simply wanted to become better at helping people. Whether I was working in sales, leading a team, coaching employees, teaching students, training clients, or mentoring young entrepreneurs, my goal was always the same, to leave people better than I found them.

Looking back, it's interesting how many different industries I've worked in. Telecommunications, financial services, retail management, fitness, transportation, education, marketing, and community leadership may seem unrelated on the surface, but they all shared one common element. Every role depended on understanding people.

As the years passed, I began to notice something that I couldn't ignore. The people who consistently achieved the best results weren't necessarily the smartest, the most experienced, or the most charismatic. They were the people who understood others better than everyone else.

They didn't rush to provide answers.

They didn't assume they already knew the problem.

Instead, they listened.

They observed.

They remained curious.

They asked thoughtful questions long before they offered thoughtful solutions.

Unfortunately, I also noticed something else.

Most conversations followed a very different pattern. Someone would describe a problem, and within seconds another person would begin explaining how to solve it. Advice came quickly. Recommendations came even faster. Yet surprisingly often, those solutions missed the real issue entirely.

It wasn't because people lacked knowledge or experience.

It was because they hadn't spent enough time understanding the need.

One lesson became increasingly clear to me throughout my career.

People usually tell us what they want before they tell us what they need.

That realization changed the way I approached conversations.

Whether I was helping someone choose a product, coaching an employee through a difficult situation, teaching a student a new skill, or working with a personal training client, I found myself becoming less interested in giving answers and more interested in asking better questions.

I began paying attention to conversations that produced exceptional outcomes. I reflected on discussions that seemed effortless and others that fell apart despite good intentions. Gradually, patterns began to emerge. Regardless of the industry, meaningful conversations almost always followed a similar progression. First came awareness, then curiosity, followed by understanding, and finally, an informed decision.

Those observations became notes.

The notes became ideas.

The ideas became a framework.

Eventually, those ideas evolved into what I now call the **NEED Cycle**.

Although it was born from years of experience in consultative sales, I quickly realized it was never just about sales. At its core, the NEED Cycle is about people. It provides a practical way to approach conversations with curiosity instead of assumptions, helping us understand before we recommend, listen before we lead, and diagnose before we attempt to solve.

Because when we truly understand people, better conversations become possible. Better conversations lead to better decisions. And better decisions almost always lead to better outcomes.

# Chapter 2

## The Moment Everything Changed

For years, I believed that experience naturally made us better at helping people. The more products we learned, the more situations we encountered, and the more conversations we had, the better equipped we became to solve problems.

In many ways, that's true.

Experience gives us knowledge. It helps us recognize patterns, anticipate challenges, and build confidence. But experience also creates a hidden danger.

It can tempt us to believe we've already seen this situation before.

We've all been there. Someone begins explaining a problem, and within moments our minds race ahead. We start connecting the dots, remembering similar situations, and thinking about the solution we would recommend. Long before the other person has finished speaking, we've already begun preparing our answer.

The intention is usually good. We want to help. We want to save time. We want to demonstrate our expertise.

Unfortunately, that's often the moment we stop listening.

I began noticing this pattern everywhere. It happened in sales conversations, performance reviews, coaching sessions, customer service interactions, and even in everyday conversations with family and friends. People weren't failing because they lacked knowledge. They were failing because they were solving the first problem they heard instead of discovering the real problem.

That realization caused me to rethink the way I approached every important conversation.

Instead of asking, *"What's the solution?"* I began asking a different question.

*"Do I truly understand what's happening here?"*

That single question changed everything.

Rather than treating conversations as opportunities to provide answers, I started viewing them as opportunities to discover understanding. Every question uncovered another piece of information. Every answer revealed another perspective. Every conversation became less about convincing someone and more about learning from them.

As I reflected on thousands of conversations throughout my career, a pattern began to emerge. The best conversations rarely jumped straight to recommendations. Instead, they followed a natural progression. First, we noticed what was happening. Then we explored it with curiosity. Next, we evaluated what we had learned to separate assumptions from reality. Only then were we truly ready to determine the best path forward.

The framework wasn't born in a single brainstorming session. It evolved over months of reflection, testing, and refinement. Every time I thought I had it figured out, another conversation taught me something new. The framework continued to evolve because people are wonderfully complex, and meaningful conversations rarely follow a perfect script.

Eventually, those recurring patterns became four simple words that captured the entire process.

Notice.

Explore.

Evaluate.

Determine.

Together, they formed the NEED Cycle.

The simplicity of those four words is intentional.

The NEED Cycle isn't designed to give people a script to memorize. It isn't a checklist to complete or a sales technique to master. Instead, it serves as a guide, a way of thinking that reminds us to stay curious, remain objective, and resist the temptation to solve a problem before we've fully understood it.



**Figure 2.** *The NEED Cycle provides a practical framework for understanding people before recommending solutions.*

Since developing the framework, I've found myself returning to it in almost every meaningful conversation. Whether I'm coaching an employee, teaching a workshop, mentoring a student, helping a customer, or simply talking with a friend, the NEED Cycle reminds me that understanding isn't a step in the conversation.

It's the foundation of the conversation.

# Chapter 3

## Looking Below the Surface

One of the greatest mistakes we make in conversations is believing the first answer is the complete answer.

Most of the time, it isn't.

When someone walks into a store and says, "I'm looking for a laptop," they're not really telling you what they need. They're telling you what they think will solve their problem.

When someone says they want a new phone, they're rarely buying a phone.

They might be buying reliability.

Convenience.

Better photos of their children.

Peace of mind.

Status.

Connection.

The phone is simply the tool they believe will deliver those things.

The same principle applies far beyond sales.

An employee asking for more training may actually need confidence.

A student asking for extra help may really need encouragement.

A customer asking for a refund may simply want to feel heard.

A friend asking for advice may not be looking for answers at all. They may simply need someone to listen.

Too often we respond to the request instead of exploring the reason behind it.

As professionals, we naturally want to solve problems. We pride ourselves on our knowledge and experience. Yet our expertise can sometimes become our greatest weakness because it



encourages us to recognize patterns before we've fully understood the individual standing in front of us.

I've learned that the first answer is rarely the whole story.

Sometimes it's only the beginning.

Curiosity gives people permission to keep talking.

Trust encourages them to reveal what really matters.

Only then do we begin to understand the need beneath the request.



**Figure 3.** *The visible request is often only a small part of the conversation. The deeper need usually lies beneath the surface.*

Whenever I catch myself thinking, "I already know where this conversation is going," I take it as a warning.

It's a reminder that I'm beginning to rely on assumptions rather than discovery.

I've found that the best conversations often begin with a simple mindset.

Assume you don't know.

Be curious.

Ask one more question.

Then ask another.

Not because you're trying to sell something.

Because you're trying to understand someone.

That shift changes everything.

Once we stop chasing answers and begin exploring understanding, conversations become richer, relationships become stronger, and solutions become far more meaningful.

The NEED Cycle begins long before we recommend anything.

It begins with curiosity.

**"People don't need better salespeople.  
They need better listeners."**

*Kevin Young*

# Chapter 4

## Notice: The Skill Most People Skip

The first stage of the NEED Cycle is also the one most people overlook.

We live in a world that rewards quick answers. Whether we're serving customers, leading employees, coaching athletes, teaching students, or helping a friend, we often feel pressure to respond immediately. We assume that speed demonstrates confidence and expertise.

In reality, speed often comes at the expense of understanding.

Notice is the discipline of slowing down long enough to truly observe what's happening before attempting to influence the outcome. It means paying attention not only to what someone says, but also to how they say it. It means recognizing emotions, body language, tone of voice, hesitation, enthusiasm, and the context surrounding the conversation.

A customer may say they're "just looking," but their questions suggest they've already done extensive research. An employee may insist everything is fine while their body language tells a different story. A student may struggle with an assignment, not because they lack ability, but because they're afraid of making a mistake.

If we only hear words, we'll often miss the real conversation.

Notice requires intentional observation. Before asking questions or offering recommendations, take a moment to understand the environment, the circumstances, and the person in front of you. Ask yourself:

- What do I know?
- What am I assuming?
- What am I missing?
- What deserves my curiosity?

These questions keep us grounded and prevent us from jumping to conclusions too quickly.

One habit I've developed over the years is resisting the urge to solve the problem during the first few minutes of a conversation. Instead, I challenge myself to simply observe. What patterns am I seeing? What emotions are present? Is there something the other person is trying to communicate indirectly?

The answers often change the direction of the entire conversation.

Notice is not passive.

It is an active decision to become fully present.

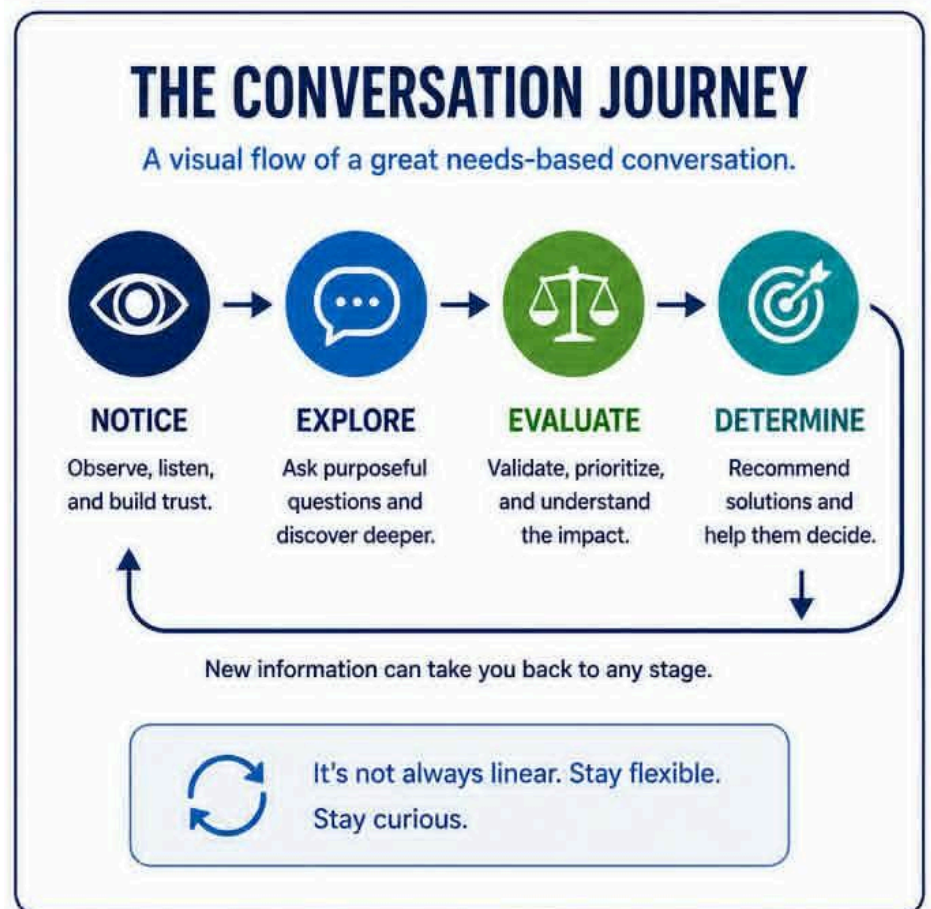
When we notice well, we ask better questions. When we ask better questions, we gain better understanding. Better understanding leads to better decisions, stronger relationships, and more meaningful outcomes.

Every stage of the NEED Cycle depends on this first step.

If we fail to notice, every stage that follows is built on assumptions rather than understanding.

That's why Notice isn't simply the first step in the framework.

It's the foundation of everything that follows.



**Figure 4.** Every meaningful conversation begins with awareness. Before we can explore, evaluate, or determine the best solution, we must first notice what is really happening.

# Chapter 5

## Explore: Curiosity Creates Understanding

Once we've taken the time to notice what's happening, the next step is to explore. This is where meaningful conversations begin to separate themselves from ordinary ones.

Most people ask questions for one of two reasons. They either want information, or they want confirmation. Unfortunately, many conversations become focused on confirming what we already believe instead of discovering what we don't yet know.

The Explore stage challenges us to replace assumptions with curiosity.

Curiosity is one of the most valuable skills a leader, coach, educator, salesperson, or mentor can possess. It creates trust, encourages openness, and allows people to feel heard without feeling judged. More importantly, curiosity often uncovers information that would never have surfaced if we had simply accepted the first answer.

I've learned that the first answer is rarely the complete answer.

Someone may tell you what they want, but they haven't necessarily told you why they want it. They may describe a symptom without understanding the underlying cause. They may ask for a specific solution simply because it's the only solution they know.

Our responsibility isn't to challenge people.

It's to understand them.

That means asking thoughtful questions that encourage reflection rather than interrogation. Good questions don't make people feel defensive. They make people feel understood.

Questions such as:

- "Can you tell me more about that?"
- "What led you to that conclusion?"
- "How has that been affecting you?"
- "What would success look like for you?"
- "What have you already tried?"

Each answer provides another piece of the puzzle. As understanding grows, assumptions begin to disappear.



**Figure 5.** Meaningful conversations rarely begin with the deepest question. Trust is built one question at a time, allowing each answer to naturally lead to the next.

The Question Ladder reminds us that great conversations are progressive. We don't begin at the top. We earn the opportunity to ask deeper questions by first creating a safe environment where people feel comfortable sharing their thoughts and experiences.

This takes patience.

It also takes discipline.

Many of us feel pressure to demonstrate our expertise by providing quick answers. In reality, expertise is often demonstrated by asking thoughtful questions that help others gain clarity for themselves.

One of the most rewarding moments in any conversation is when the other person pauses and says, "I've never thought about it that way before."

That moment rarely happens because we gave them an answer.

It happens because we asked a question that encouraged them to discover one.

The Explore stage isn't about collecting information.

It's about building understanding.

When people feel genuinely understood, they're far more willing to trust our recommendations because they know those recommendations are based on their needs rather than our assumptions.

Every meaningful solution begins with meaningful curiosity.



# Chapter 6

## Evaluate: Separating Wants from Needs

Exploration gives us information. Evaluation gives that information meaning.

This is the stage where we begin connecting the dots. We've listened carefully, asked thoughtful questions, and gained a deeper understanding of the person in front of us. Now it's time to step back and determine what we've actually learned.

One of the biggest mistakes professionals make is believing that gathering information automatically leads to understanding. It doesn't.

Information is only valuable when we take the time to interpret it accurately.

During the Evaluate stage, we're looking for patterns, priorities, and possibilities. We're asking ourselves questions like:

- What is the real challenge?
- What outcome is this person truly trying to achieve?
- What obstacles are standing in the way?
- What assumptions have been proven wrong?
- Have I earned enough understanding to make a recommendation?

These questions force us to slow down and think critically before moving toward a solution.

I've learned that the most obvious problem is rarely the most important one.

A customer may believe they need a lower price when what they really need is greater confidence in the purchase.

An employee may ask for additional training when what they really need is clearer expectations and regular feedback.

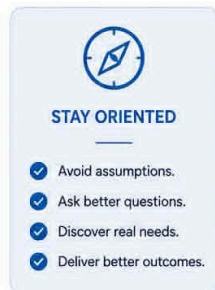
A leader may believe they have a performance problem when the real issue is communication.

The goal of the Evaluate stage is to separate symptoms from causes.

# THE NEED COMPASS

Stay oriented toward what matters most.

The NEED Compass keeps you focused on the customer's true north—so every conversation moves in the right direction.



**W DETERMINE**  
Recommend with confidence.  
Help them decide.



**N NOTICE**  
Observe & listen  
without leading.

**E EXPLORE**  
Ask questions.  
Go deeper.

**S EVALUATE**  
Validate & prioritize.  
Understand impact.



**Right Direction**  
Focus on the person.



**Clear Vision**  
See what's below  
the surface.



**Better Outcomes**  
Guide to the right  
solution together.

**When you stay oriented,  
you help them find their way.**

**Figure 6.** *The Compass reminds us to stay oriented toward understanding rather than drifting toward assumptions. Every conversation should keep pointing back to the learner, customer, employee, or individual we're trying to help.*

The Compass is a reminder that meaningful conversations don't always move in a straight line. Sometimes a new piece of information requires us to return to an earlier question. Sometimes we discover an assumption that needs to be challenged. Sometimes we realize we've been solving the wrong problem altogether.

That's not failure.

That's progress.

Evaluation isn't about proving ourselves right.

It's about making sure we're solving the right problem.

Only when we're confident that we've identified the true need should we move to the final stage of the NEED Cycle.

Because the quality of our recommendation will never exceed the quality of our understanding.

# Chapter 7

## Determine: The Right Solution for the Right Reason

The final stage of the NEED Cycle is often the one people are most eager to reach.

After all, this is where decisions are made. Recommendations are offered. Problems are solved.

Ironically, the Determine stage is also the easiest stage to get wrong.

Not because we lack knowledge or experience.

But because we sometimes arrive here too soon.

One of the greatest lessons I've learned is that a good solution offered too early can become the wrong solution. Even if the recommendation is technically correct, it may fail because it wasn't built on a complete understanding of the person's situation.

By the time we reach the Determine stage, our role is no longer to persuade.

Our role is to guide.

We've earned the opportunity to make a recommendation because we've taken the time to listen, explore, and evaluate. The recommendation is no longer based on assumptions. It's based on understanding.

That changes the conversation completely.

Instead of saying,

*"Here's what you need."*

We're able to say,

*"Based on everything you've shared with me, I believe this solution best aligns with the goals and challenges you've described. Let me explain why."*

That's a very different conversation.

The first statement is built on confidence.

The second is built on credibility.

People are far more likely to trust a recommendation when they feel it was created specifically for them rather than selected from a script.

However, even at this stage, we need to remain open to learning.

One of the biggest discoveries I made while developing the NEED Cycle was realizing that the first legitimate need we uncover isn't always the most important one.

Sometimes we ask a great question, uncover a genuine need, and immediately begin building a solution around it.

The problem is that the conversation isn't finished.

Often, another question reveals an even deeper need.

That deeper need changes everything.



**Figure 7.** *The first legitimate need is often real, but not always the most important. Resist the temptation to stop exploring simply because you've found a problem worth solving.*

This idea fundamentally changed the way I approach conversations.

Today, whenever I believe I've identified the need, I challenge myself with one final question.

*"Is there anything more important that I haven't discovered yet?"*

Sometimes the answer is no.

Sometimes that one question changes the entire direction of the conversation.

The Determine stage isn't about closing a sale or ending a discussion.

It's about arriving at a solution with confidence because the journey to get there has been thoughtful, intentional, and centred on the other person.

When we take the time to Notice, Explore, Evaluate, and only then Determine, our recommendations become more relevant, our relationships become stronger, and the people we serve are far more likely to feel understood.

That, ultimately, is the purpose of the NEED Cycle.

Not to help us become better at giving answers.

To help us become better at understanding people before we give them.

# Chapter 8

## Beyond Sales: A Framework for Human Conversations

When people first see the NEED Cycle, they often assume it's a sales model.

I understand why.

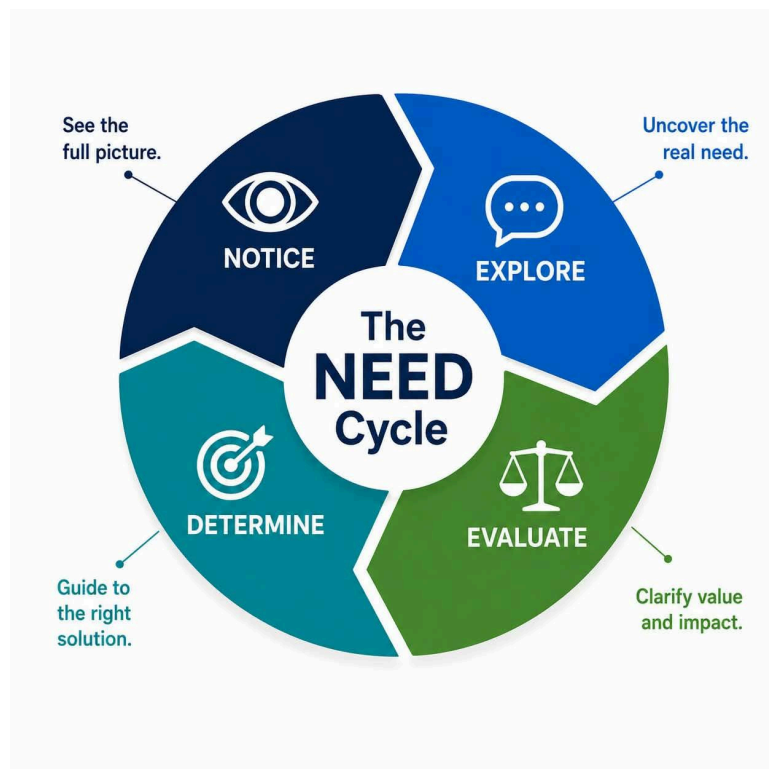
After all, it was inspired by years of working in consultative sales and leadership. Many of the examples throughout this guide involve helping customers make informed decisions.

But the longer I used the framework, the more I realized it had very little to do with sales.

It had everything to do with people.

Every meaningful conversation begins the same way. One person is trying to understand another. Whether we're leading a team, coaching an employee, teaching a student, resolving a conflict, supporting a friend, or helping a customer, the process is remarkably similar.

We notice what is happening. We explore with curiosity. We evaluate what we've learned. Then, and only then, do we determine the best path forward. The NEED Cycle isn't a script. It's a mindset. It reminds us that understanding should always come before influence.



**Figure 8.** *The NEED Cycle is a communication framework that extends far beyond sales into leadership, education, coaching, healthcare, customer service, human resources, conflict resolution, and everyday life.*

I've seen these principles appear in almost every role I've held.

As a leader, I've learned that employees rarely need more rules. More often, they need clarity, encouragement, and someone willing to understand the obstacles they're facing.

As a coach, I've discovered that people rarely struggle because they lack information. More often, they struggle because they lack confidence, accountability, or a clear path forward.

As an educator, I've learned that every learner is different. The same lesson can inspire one student while confusing another. Effective teaching isn't about delivering identical instruction. It's about adapting to the individual.

Even in our personal relationships, the NEED Cycle continues to prove its value.

How often do we interrupt someone before they've finished speaking?

How often do we begin defending ourselves before we've fully understood another person's perspective?

How often do we offer advice when someone simply needs to feel heard?

The NEED Cycle challenges us to pause. To become curious. To seek understanding before offering solutions.

Imagine what would change if leaders spent more time understanding employees than correcting them.

If teachers spent more time discovering how students learn than simply delivering information.

If healthcare professionals spent more time understanding patient concerns before discussing treatment.

If families spent more time asking questions instead of making assumptions.

The quality of our conversations would improve.

And when conversations improve, relationships improve.

When relationships improve, trust grows.

When trust grows, better decisions naturally follow.

That is why I no longer think of the NEED Cycle as a sales framework.

I believe it is a human communication framework.

Because regardless of our profession, our title, or our experience, we all face the same responsibility.

To understand people before trying to help them.

And that responsibility never goes out of style.

# Chapter 9

## Where Do We Go From Here?

The NEED Cycle was never intended to be a finished product.

In many ways, this guide represents the beginning rather than the end of its journey.

Every meaningful conversation I have continues to teach me something new. Every workshop, coaching session, leadership discussion, and customer interaction offers another opportunity to test the framework, challenge my assumptions, and improve the ideas you've read throughout this guide.

That is exactly how the NEED Cycle was created.

Not in a boardroom.

Not in a classroom.

Not through a single moment of inspiration.

It was built one conversation at a time.

As I continue to share this framework with leaders, educators, coaches, sales professionals, and organizations, I fully expect it to evolve. New examples will emerge. Better questions will be discovered. Different perspectives will strengthen the model.

I welcome that.

In fact, I believe any framework that stops evolving eventually stops being useful.

My hope is that the NEED Cycle becomes more than something you read.

I hope it becomes something you practice.

The next time you walk into an important meeting, pause for a moment.

Notice before you speak.

Explore before you advise.

Evaluate before you conclude.

Determine only after you've earned the right to recommend.



Those four habits have changed the way I communicate, lead, coach, teach, and solve problems. I believe they have the potential to do the same for anyone willing to embrace them.



**Figure 9.** *The NEED Cycle is not a checklist. It is a mindset that can guide every meaningful conversation.*

If this guide encourages you to ask one better question, listen a little longer, challenge one assumption, or help one person feel more understood, then it has accomplished exactly what I hoped it would.

The world doesn't need more people rushing to provide answers.

It needs more people willing to understand before they respond.

That is the future I hope to contribute to.

One conversation at a time.

# About the Author

Kevin Young is a Learning & Development professional, facilitator, coach, and lifelong student of human behaviour. Throughout a career spanning more than two decades, he has worked across telecommunications, financial services, retail leadership, fitness, transportation, education, marketing, and community organizations. While the industries have varied, one theme has remained constant: helping people grow.

Kevin has trained and coached employees, mentored aspiring entrepreneurs through Junior Achievement, taught music to students from Kindergarten through Grade 12, instructed clients as an ISSA Certified Personal Trainer, and led teams focused on improving performance through practical coaching and meaningful conversations. These diverse experiences reinforced a belief that people are far more likely to succeed when they feel understood before they are advised.

That belief became the foundation of the NEED Cycle, an original communication framework designed to help leaders, coaches, educators, sales professionals, and anyone who works with people move beyond assumptions and toward genuine understanding. Rather than offering another sales methodology, the NEED Cycle encourages curiosity, thoughtful questioning, and intentional listening as the path to stronger relationships and better decisions.

Kevin believes that learning should always be practical, engaging, and immediately applicable. His approach combines real-world experience with a passion for coaching, facilitation, and continuous improvement. Whether speaking to a classroom, coaching an employee, facilitating a workshop, or simply having a conversation over coffee, his goal remains the same: to help people ask better questions, think more deeply, and discover solutions that truly meet the needs of those they serve.

Outside of his professional work, Kevin enjoys hockey, music, martial arts, fitness, writing, and exploring new ideas through his YouTube channel, **Discovering Life with Kevin**. He lives in Corner Brook, Newfoundland and Labrador, where he continues to develop the NEED Cycle through workshops, presentations, and ongoing collaboration with learners and professionals from a variety of industries.



# Thank You

*"People don't need better answers.*

*They need people who care enough to ask better questions."*

**Kevin Young**

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## Connect with Kevin

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## The NEED Cycle

*Understanding People Before Offering Solutions*